

Chapter 26_1 - Jealousy

"If Master wants new clothes, there's a place in the sect for making them. I could just give instructions - why trouble yourself?" Qiu Yi said as she walked back, but was called to stop by Chu Qingqiu.

"The sect's clothing is quite mediocre and inferior." Chu Qingqiu shook her head. "In the gifts sent by Tianji Sword Sect a few days ago, I remember there was a bundle of fabric woven from Heavenly Mountain immortal grass leaves. Is it still in the palace?"

"Yes, I'll go get it immediately." Qiu Yi answered, but then smiled bitterly. "But Master, this disciple is also completely ignorant about making clothes. Even if I bring the fabric, I'd be helpless. It would be better to go down the mountain to find some tailors or seamstresses and pay them to do it."

Chu Qingqiu was silent for a while, then suddenly asked: "There's a managing disciple in the West Courtyard who's often with Ning Fuyi - what's his name again?"

"Rong Jin?" Qiu Yi scratched her head.

"Mm." Chu Qingqiu sat down gracefully and reached out to touch the dried flowers. "Summon him."

Qiu Yi acknowledged and was about to turn around when Chu Qingqiu called her back again. She helplessly turned in place once more, but didn't dare say anything and continued to bow.

"How is your investigation into the Furong Town matter progressing?" Chu Qingqiu looked up. When discussing serious matters, she inexplicably commanded respect, making one not dare to look directly at her.

"Reporting to Master, I found the remains of the Flying Eagle Boat¹ in Tongchuan. The mechanisms were intact, with no immortal power residue or remaining talismans. From the break patterns, it looked like it was torn apart by enormous force." Qiu Yi replied.

"Do you think there was something suspicious about that accident?" Seeing Chu Qingqiu's expression unchanged, Qiu Yi asked carefully. "But the elders sent to investigate said it was due to the Flying Eagle Boat aging from lack of maintenance, combined with the heavy miasma and strong winds from Ghost Eye that day."

"I just find it strange that only Ning Fuyi fell from such an accident." Chu Qingqiu said, waving her hand. "Alright, you may go."

Though Qiu Yi still had doubts, she didn't dare ask more. She bowed and finally left.

Ning Fuyi had been delayed at Jingshan Palace for a long time. By the time she ran breathlessly to Xuanliang Courtyard², the afternoon immortal lessons had already begun. The courtyard was quiet except for the sounds of elders teaching from various halls.

Ning Fuyi sighed and tiptoed across the corridor, crouching as she passed under the windows, then half-squatted at the doorway.

Today's lesson was on array formations, taught by the strictest Elder Pingyao³. Ning Fuyi groaned inwardly and secretly peered into the room.

Several rows of seats were completely full - no disciple dared skip Elder Pingyao's classes. Only her seat and Li Zhao'an's were empty. Liu Wenzhu, sitting at the same table, caught her eye and widened her eyes at her.

"Help me." Ning Fuyi gestured to her.

Liu Wenzhu closed her eyes, looked with difficulty at Elder Pingyao who was teaching enthusiastically, shook her pale face at Ning Fuyi, indicating she was powerless to help.

Ning Fuyi simply pressed her palms together with a pitiful expression. Liu Wenzhu was soft-hearted after all. Covering her face with her hands, she suddenly stood up as if going to her death, interrupting Elder Pingyao's flow: "Elder Pingyao, could you draw that array formation again? I forgot to write it down."

Her clear voice drew everyone's attention. Elder Pingyao's raised hand stopped in mid-air, her brows furrowing as if she wanted to say something. But since the speaker was Liu Wenzhu, who was always diligent and obedient, she ultimately didn't scold her.

"Don't let your mind wander next time." Elder Pingyao instructed, then turned around and raised her finger again, drawing the array diagram in the void.

Ning Fuyi took advantage of her turned back to sprint forward, running back to her seat in a few steps. By the time Elder Pingyao turned around again, she was already sitting properly with her chin propped up.

Elder Pingyao's gaze seemed to linger on her for a moment. Just as Ning Fuyi's heart was in her throat, the elder looked away.

"Tracking Array⁴ - as the name suggests, it can find lost objects or missing people. If the array is used correctly, the search range can span across the four seas and eight wastelands⁵. Array studies are profound and extensive. Using people as arrays, stones as arrays, or ink as arrays all have different effects."

"Similarly, sometimes what appears to be an ordinary array can have earth-shaking changes with just one or two modifications to its shapes. But we North Courtyard disciples have shallow cultivation and must never arbitrarily change arrays when casting them, as this could very likely harm ourselves."

The array behind her shimmered brilliantly. Ning Fuyi watched with fascination and suddenly took Liu Wenzhu's paper from the desk, copying down the array formation.

"How rare - our Yiyi is actually paying attention to a lesson for once." Liu Wenzhu smiled warmly. She secretly poked Ning Fuyi's arm. "After I helped Elder Yuanming move the stone lion, I couldn't find you anywhere. Where did you go? What did Elder Yuanming secretly tell you?"

"I went to deliver the Crimson Jade Sect Seal to Chu Qingqiu." Ning Fuyi replied while putting the copied array into her sleeve. "Elder Yuanming said Man'er is very special - her true form is a precious immortal herb, and he wants me to look after her when I have time."

"That young girl is indeed pitiful. Spirit Clan members have no parents to begin with, and she was captured right after transforming, witnessing so many bloody scenes. It's right that we should take more care of her." Liu Wenzhu sighed with sympathy.

"She doesn't need much looking after. When she grows up, we'll just send her back to Heavenly Mountain." Ning Fuyi said casually.

The distant mountains merged into one, and when the sun set in the west, the day's lessons ended. The disciples all stretched and yawned in a mess. Elder Pingyao suddenly tapped the desk and said seriously: "Everyone wait, this elder has one more announcement."

The hall quieted down. Dozens of eyes stared at Elder Pingyao.

"The Zhaoyao Conference is approaching. As you all know, this time disciples below the Clear Realm⁶ also have quotas. But there are many North Courtyard disciples, and the elders and sect leader cannot privately determine candidates, so we've decided to hold selections tomorrow. Therefore, lessons are suspended tomorrow, and all North Courtyard disciples planning to participate in the selection should gather at Cloud Deep Hall⁷ at Chen hour⁸."

"Everyone may disperse." After Elder Pingyao finished speaking, she turned and left Xuanliang Courtyard, leaving the disciples chattering noisily.

"Open selection? Though we usually spar, I've never really fought anyone before. I have no confidence at all." Someone behind Ning Fuyi said loudly.

"What do you have to fear as someone in Rising Realm⁹? I'm just in Mortal Realm - I never planned to participate anyway. Tomorrow I can stay in Treasure Qi Studio¹⁰ and have a good sleep!" Another male disciple said as he walked out, prompting several others to echo his sentiment.

"I just broke through to Rising Realm, and I only know wood-type techniques. How can I fight those fire and thunder types? Forget it, I'll sleep tomorrow too." The previous speaker hopped after the group, leaving together.

"Yiyi..." Liu Wenzhu suddenly leaned over softly, but Ning Fuyi tilted her body to avoid her.

"Don't try to persuade me. Even those in Rising Realm know they have no chance of winning. I just broke through Mortal Realm - if I face some powerful opponents, wouldn't they want half my life?" Ning Fuyi shook her head. "Don't worry, you're about to break through to Clear Realm, and you have the most powerful fire-type techniques. The selection won't be a problem for you."

Liu Wenzhu looked at her with bright, sparkling eyes and said pitifully: "Are you really not going to try? Without you accompanying me, going to Zhaoyao Mountain alone would be so boring."

"There's still Senior Brother Rong Jin. His cultivation will definitely get him selected - how could it be boring?" Ning Fuyi comforted her, then suddenly remembered something and looked around. "Speaking of Senior Brother Rong Jin, he usually comes to find us when lessons end. Everyone's gone now - why is there still no sign of him?"

Liu Wenzhu was also distracted by this, looking out the window: "Yes, how strange. Perhaps he was delayed by something. Let's go back first."

"I'll accompany you for dinner." Liu Wenzhu affectionately linked arms with Ning Fuyi, and the two went to the dining hall talking and laughing.

Ning Fuyi had something on her mind, so after dinner she excused herself saying she was tired, bid farewell to Liu Wenzhu, and walked alone down a secluded path. At the end of the path was a wooden house that looked quite rustic but was kept very clean, surrounded by a fence covered in wild roses. It looked completely out of place compared to other areas of Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate.

This place was given to her by Ning Changfeng when he was still alive. Back then, Ning Fuyi was young and saw that other sects' young leaders all had their own chambers, while she still slept in dormitories with other disciples. Very dissatisfied, she cried and demanded that Ning Changfeng prepare one for her too. Initially, Ning Changfeng disagreed, but after she grabbed his ears and cried for three days, he couldn't stand it anymore and assigned her a wooden house in a corner that had been used for storing miscellaneous items.

At first, Ning Fuyi was happy to have her own residence, but later when she learned this place was originally used for storing brooms, she became disgusted and never set foot there again.

It wasn't until three nights ago during a midnight walk that she remembered this place. After cleaning it up, it became a place where she could be alone.

She brushed off the fallen leaves from her shoulders and entered the house with the scent of grass and trees. Though small, the wooden house had everything - courtyard, main hall, study, and bedroom were all complete. She walked to the study in a few steps, pushed aside the scattered papers on the desk, and placed the array formation she had copied during the day in the center.

Whether cultivating immortality or demonhood, the most important thing was having one's own magical artifact. In her previous life, her artifact was an Emei spike¹¹ that could summon heavenly thunder. It was said to be a relic of an ancient evil spirit and a treasure coveted throughout the entire demon realm.

In her past life, the Emei spike was seized from someone else. As soon as she touched it, it rang loudly and quickly recognized her as its master. If she could have this treasure's assistance in this life, her demonic cultivation path would be much smoother.

But these past few days, she had tried searching with demon clan arrays without sensing that familiar aura. She had thought things were at an impasse, but after hearing Elder Pingyao's lesson on array formations today, she suddenly had some risky ideas.

Perhaps she couldn't sense the Emei spike's aura because her power was insufficient to probe distant places. If she combined the two types of arrays, might she have different results?

Ning Fuyi studied the two arrays for a long time, then stood up to find a larger piece of paper, picked up a brush, and began drawing seriously.

Footnotes:

1. **Flying Eagle Boat (飞鹰舟)** - A type of flying transportation vessel used by cultivators
2. **Xuanliang Courtyard (悬梁苑)** - The North Courtyard where lessons are held
3. **Elder Pingyao (平遥长老)** - One of the strict teaching elders
4. **Tracking Array (寻踪阵)** - A formation used to locate lost people or objects
5. **Four seas and eight wastelands (四海八荒)** - An idiom meaning "everywhere" or "all corners of the world"
6. **Clear Realm (明境)** - One of the cultivation realms in the story's power system
7. **Cloud Deep Hall (云深殿)** - A major hall in the sect for important gatherings
8. **Chen hour (辰时)** - 7:00-9:00 AM in the traditional Chinese time system
9. **Rising Realm (起境)** - Another cultivation realm in the story's system
10. **Treasure Qi Studio (宝气斋)** - A dormitory or rest area for disciples
11. **Emei spike (峨眉刺)** - A traditional Chinese weapon, thin metal spikes used for stabbing

Author's Notes: This chapter builds anticipation for the upcoming selection trials while showing Ning Fuyi's secret magical research. The subplot with Chu Qingqiu wanting to make clothes and her investigation into the Flying Eagle Boat incident adds layers to the developing relationship dynamics.